

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

2000-09-24

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

1 dear b ahá'í f riends,

2 with keen anticipation to the occurrence this year of millennial gatherings concerned
with global issues needing urgent solutions, and with how the united Nations is to address
them. during the first week of this month,

3 the united Nations millennium Summit, the last and most significant of
4 three related events, convened in New york with the participation of the
5 largest number of heads of state and of government ever to be assembled.

6 in view of the historic importance of this and the two earlier occasions,
7 and considering the prominent involvement of representatives of the bahá'í
8 international community in all three, the house of justice has directed us
9 to convey the following.

10 in calling for a gathering of world leaders at the 2000 session of the gen-
11 eral Assembly, the Secretary-g eneral of the united Nations also suggested
12 the merit of their inviting the views and recommendations of organizations
13 of civil society; this gave birth to the idea of a millennium forum. Another
14 thought that won the warm support of the Secretary-g eneral was that a
15 meeting of religious and spiritual leaders devoted to peace would enhance the work
of the u nited Nations.

16 Thus, the millennium forum, the first of these major gatherings,

brought together on 22–26 may more than 1,000 representatives of non-

17 governmental organizations from more than 100 countries “to consult about the role
of the united Nations in confronting the great global challenges

facing humanity in the 21

st century.” They focused their consultations

18 on the following specific topics: 1) peace, security and disarmament; 2)

19 eradication of poverty, including debt cancellation and social development;

20 3) human rights; 4) sustainable development and environment; 5) facing the
challenges of globalization: achieving equity, justice and diversity; and 6) strengthening and
democratizing the united Nations and international

organizations. 342.1

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344 77As a result, the participants in the millennium forum adopted a declara-

345 tion, for presentation to world leaders at the subsequent millennium Sum-

346 mit, in which they set forth their vision and made their recommendations

347 for revitalizing the united Nations. “i n our vision,” these representatives

348 of civil society declared, “we are one human family, in all our diversity, living on one
common homeland and sharing a just, sustainable and peace-

349 ful world, guided by universal principles of democracy, equality, inclusion,

350 voluntarism, non-discrimination and participation by all persons. . . . it is

351 a world where peace and human security, as envisioned in the principles of the
united Nations charter, replace armaments, violent conflict and wars.

352 it is a world where everyone lives in a clean environment with a fair distribu-

353 tion of the earth’s resources. our vision includes a special role for the dyna-

354 mism of young people and the experience of the elderly and reaffirms the

355 universality, indivisibility and interdependence of all human rights—civil,

political, economic, social and cultural.”

The millennium peace Summit of religious and Spiritual leaders, which

was held on 28–31 August and involved more than 1,000 attendees, con-

356 stituted the second of these gatherings. The “very specific purpose” of this

357 meeting of religious leaders was, as stated in the introductory statement of the
program, “to further the prospects for peace among peoples and nations, and within every
individual.” The outcome of this peace Summit was the

358 adoption and signing of a declaration committing the participants to global peace.
Noting that “the united Nations and the religions of the world have

359 a common concern for human dignity, justice and peace,” accepting that

360 “men and women are equal partners in all aspects of life and children are

361 the hope of the future,” and acknowledging that “religions have contributed to the
peace of the world but have also been used to create division and fuel hostilities,” the
declaration resolved to “collaborate with the united Nations

362 and all men and women of goodwill locally, regionally and globally in the pursuit of
peace in all its dimensions.”

As you were previously informed in our letter of 15 August 2000, the

Secretary-general of the bahá'í international community, mr. Albert

363 lincoln, represented the faith on this occasion. he was listed among the
364 “pre-eminent world religious and Spiritual leaders” in attendance and was
365 afforded the opportunity both to offer a bahá'í prayer during the opening
366 ceremony and to speak during the third plenary session held in the general
367 Assembly hall on the second day of the event. his oral presentation was 342.4

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343 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

344 78an abridged version of his written statement, the full text of which was
345 distributed to the participants, as shown in the enclosure.

The millennium Summit, the third and culminating event, was held in

346 response to a resolution of the general Assembly that expressed the convic-
347 tion that “the year 2000 constitutes a unique and symbolically compelling moment to
articulate and affirm an animating vision of the united Nations

348 in the new era.” on the last day, the leaders of more than 150 nations

349 unanimously adopted a declaration that began by asserting: “ we, heads of

State and government, have gathered at united Nations headquarters in

350 New york from 6 to 8 September 2000, at the dawn of a new millennium,

351 to reaffirm our faith in the organization and its charter as indispensable

foundations of a more peaceful, prosperous and just world.”

highlighting certain “fundamental values”—freedom, equality, soli-

352 darity, tolerance, respect for nature, shared responsibility—the leaders resolved to
work towards such objectives as: peace, security and disarmament; development and the
eradication of poverty; protecting our common environment; human rights, democracy and
good governance; protecting

353 the vulnerable; meeting the special needs of Africa; and strengthening the
united Nations. They made a firm commitment to world peace and world
354 order, concluding their declaration on this resounding note: “ we solemnly
355 reaffirm, on this historic occasion, that the united Nations is the indispens-
356 able common house of the entire human family, through which we will seek to
realize our universal aspirations for peace, cooperation and development. we therefore
pledge our unstinting support for these common objectives,
and our determination to achieve them.”

it is striking that the spokesman of civil society called upon by the

357 Secretary-general of the united Nations to address so historic a gathering
358 was mr. Techeste Ahderom, the principal representative of the bahá'í in-
359 ternational community to the united Nations. he was accorded this honor
360 because as its cochair he had presided at the united Nations millennium
361 forum. After all the national leaders had spoken and before the Summit
362 had adopted its declaration on 8 September, mr. Ahderom made a speech in
363 which he conveyed to that unprecedented assemblage a report of the forum.
364 The text of his speech is enclosed herewith.
365 for any observer imbued with the bahá'í vision of peace and its inher-
366 ent processes, the substance and implications of these recent events, seen together
with previous world conferences that during the last decade also involved leaders of nations,
must be gratifying indeed to contemplate. it 342.7

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344 79must, too, be doubly thrilling to realize that at so early a stage in the bahá'í
345 era, representatives of our international community took part so notably in
346 these occurrences that have set down milestones along the way towards that
347 new w orld o rder so clearly foreshadowed by the p en of b ahá'u'lláh.
348 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

for Department of tHe secretariat

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Continental Pioneer Committees

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]